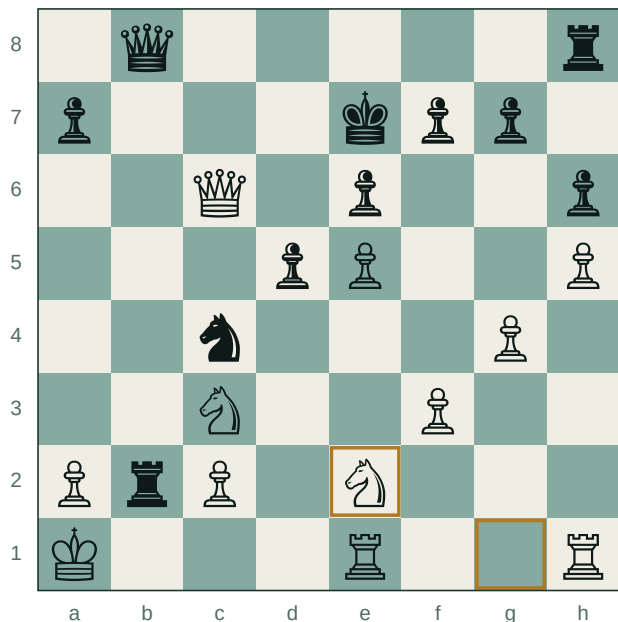


Clearance tactics: Black, move 26

Clearance tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 26.Nge2. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26...Rxa2+ 27. Nxa2 Qb2#

26...Rxa2+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on a2. Recorded reply: **27.Nxa2**.

27...Qb2# Mate: queen on b2 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on a1. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Queen on b2. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Opening a line helps only if your next move is timely. The defender may close the line or create a stronger threat.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A clearance move vacates a square or opens a line for another piece. The clearing piece may sacrifice itself to gain the time needed for the follow-up.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the rook, bishop, queen, or knight that needs access, then locate the friendly piece blocking its route or destination.

The defending king is on a1. Geometrically undefended: queen on c6. Check for tactical protection.